University of St.Gallen

Course and Examination Fact Sheet: Spring Semester 2026

8,002: Platform Economy

ECTS credits: 6

Overview examination/s

(binding regulations see below)
decentral - Presentation, Analog, Group work group grade (50%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Written examination, Digital, Individual work individual grade (40%, 60 mins.)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Written work, Digital, Individual work individual grade (10%)
Examination time: Term time

Attached courses

Timetable -- Language -- Lecturer
8,002,1.00 Platform Economy -- English -- Wortmann Felix

Course information

Prerequisites

No special prerequisites - The course addresses students who are interested in platform-based innovation, entrepreneurship and real-case company work. The course is assigned to the MBI 'Business Development' track but can also be taken without selecting a specialization.

Learning objectives

Students will …

- Understand the fundamentals of the platform economy
- Analyse and evaluate selected industries and their dominating platforms
- Be able to critically reflect on and assess existing platform businesses and their strategies
- Be able to design a platform business model

Content

Today, seven out of the ten most valuable companies globally are platform companies and many more are on the rise to disrupt entire industries. Famous examples are Amazon, Alibaba or eBay in retail, Airbnb in travelling and Uber or Didi in transportation. But it is not only digital or B2C companies that have embarked on a platform journey. Many traditional companies, also in B2B, have sought to extend their traditional business models by launching their own platform businesses, e.g. Claas (365FarmNet), Bosch (Azena), Lanxess (Chemondis), MindSphere (Siemens) or Predix (General Electric).

In light of these developments, the course will address five fundamental questions:

- What are platforms and how do their underlying mechanisms work?
- What makes platform companies so successful and how can they be differentiated?
- What platform opportunities exist in B2B?
- How can companies successfully establish and scale a platform business?
- What are the key threats to platform businesses?

Over the last two decades, platform companies have been able to outperform traditional businesses by establishing themselves as digital intermediaries. Amazon and Alibaba, for example, facilitate transactions between sellers and buyers, Apple facilitates

transactions between app developers and app users, and Google facilitates transactions between ordinary web users and advertisers. The success of all these platform depends on network effects, i.e., the flywheel effect that more platform users lead to a higher value for the platform.

However, 80% of all platform initiatives fail and traditional companies in particular struggle. One core reason for platform failure is that platform business models are just very different from traditional, so-called pipeline business models. Many companies are not aware of the diverse nature and mechanics of platforms. In addition, instead of joining forces with an existing platform to accelerate network effects and help establish a dominant position, many companies attempt to launch their own platform in order to remain independent. With limited network effects, these initiatives often falter, and ultimately none of the competing platforms succeeds.

The course is structured around a real-world case. Students will identify, analyse and compare leading B2C and B2B platforms in selected domains. Working in groups, they will develop a competitive platform strategy for the case company. The group work will draw on a variety of methods, e.g. literature reviews, internet research, interviews, as well as our pattern-based framework (The Platform Navigator). The group project is complemented by an exam as well as peer feedback. Overall, a high degree of self-study is expected.

Structure and indications of the learning and teaching design

- This course is worth 6 credits. Accordingly, the total workload for students is 180 hours. This includes self-study, campus time and all examinations.
- The structure of the contact study is planned as follows:
    - Two introductory lectures (kick-off seminars), 5 hours each
    - Two guest lectures, 1 hour each
    - Two coaching sessions of 2.5 hours each throughout the semester
    - Two final presentation sessions, 6 & 7 hours, consisting of the concluding group presentations
- The structure of the self-study is intended as follows:
    - 30 hours of preparation time for the lectures
    - 120 hours for the examinations (group presentation, individual exam and individual peer feedback)
- The course takes place in person in St. Gallen and in a blended learning format via StudyNet, where a series of pre-recorded teaching videos will be provided.

Literature

- Adner, R. (2021). Winning the right game: How to disrupt, defend, and deliver in a changing world. MIT Press.
- Cusumano, M., Yoffie, D., & Gawer, A. (2020). The future of platforms. MIT Sloan Management Review.
- Cusumano, M. A., Gawer, A., & Yoffie, D. B. (2019). The business of platforms: Strategy in the age of digital competition, innovation, and power (First Edition ed.). Harper Business New York.
- Eisenmann, T., Parker, G., & Van Alstyne, M. (2009). Strategies for Two-Sided Markets. Harvard Business Review.
- Gassmann, O. & Ferrandina, F. (Eds.). (2021): Connected Business: Create Value in a Networked Economy. Cham: Springer.
- Gawer, A., & Cusumano, M. (2008). How Companies Become Platform Leaders. MIT Sloan Management Review.
- Hagiu, A., & Wright, J. (2024). Will That Marketplace Succeed? Harvard Business Review, 103(4), 94-103.
- Hein, A., Schreieck, M., Riasanow, T., Setzke, D. S., Wiesche, M., Böhm, M., & Krcmar, H. (2020). Digital platform ecosystems. Electronic Markets.
- Hodapp, D., Hawlitschek, F., Wortmann, F., Lang, M., & Gassmann, O. (2022). Key Lessons from Bosch for Incumbent Firms Entering the Platform Economy. MIS Quarterly Executive, 21(2), 115-126.
- Jung, S., Wortmann, F., Bronner, W., & Gassmann, O. (2021). Platform Economy: Converging IoT Platforms and Ecosystems.
- Parker, G. G., Van Alstyne, M. W., & Choudary, S. P. (2016). Platform revolution: How networked markets are transforming the economy and how to make them work for you. WW Norton & Company.
- Rietveld, J. & Schilling, M. A. (2020). Platform Competition: A Systematic and Interdisciplinary Review of the Literature. Journal of Management.
- Springer, V., Randhawa, K., Jovanović, M., Ritala, P., & Piller, F. T. (2025). Platform design and governance in industrial markets: Charting the meta-organizational logic. Research policy, 54(6), 105236.
- Van Alstyne, M., Parker, G., & Choudary, S. (2016). Pipelines, Platforms, and the New Rules of Strategy. Harvard Business Review.
- Van Dyck, M., Lüttgens, D., Diener, K., Piller, F., & Pollok, P. (2024). From product to platform: How incumbents' assumptions and choices shape their platform strategy. Research policy, 53(1), 104904.
- Wlcek, M., Gawer, A., Gassmann, O., & Wortmann, F. (forthcoming). How Managers Get B2B Marketplace Scaling Wrong. MIS Quarterly Executive.
- Wortmann, F., Jung, S., & Gassmann, O. (2024). The Platform Business Navigator. Financial Times Publishing.

- Wortmann, F., Jung, S., Bronner, W., & Gassmann, O. (2021). The Platform Navigator: 88 Patterns to Design and Implement Platform Business Models. White Paper at University of St. Gallen
- Zhu, F., & Iansiti, M. (2019). Why Some Platforms Thrive and Others Don't. Harvard Business Review.

Additional information

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Examination information

Examination sub part/s

1. Examination sub part (1/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Presentation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Group work group grade
Weighting	50%
Duration	--

Languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark

Group Presentation

Examination-aid rule

Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids

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2. Examination sub part (2/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Written examination
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Written exam
Examination mode	Digital
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Synchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade

Weighting	40%
Duration	60 mins.

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
Individual Exam

Examination-aid rule
Closed Book

The use of aids is prohibited as a matter of principle, with the exception of pocket calculator models of the Texas Instruments TI-30 series and, in case of non-language exams, bilingual dictionaries without any handwritten notes. Any other aids that are admissible must be explicitly listed by faculty members in the paragraph entitled "Supplementary aids" of the course and examination fact sheet; this list is exhaustive.

Procuring any aids, as well as ensuring their working order, is the exclusive responsibility of students.

Supplementary aids

The examination will be conducted as a digital examination with the following admissible devices:

- **Private notebook** (compulsory) – no tablets!
- **Mains adapter** (compulsory)
- External computer mouse (optional)
- External computer keyboard (optional)

We expressly point out that the examination cannot be taken with tablets/iPads

Technical requirements:

- Appliance and system requirements: cf. StudentWeb
- Special software: LockDown Browser
- HSG log-in including access modalities
- WLAN – operational access to Eduroam

Please make sure that

- all the updates have been carried out before the examination.
- in the run-up to digitally conducted examinations, technical tests (mock examinations without grades) are carried out. Participation is urgently required!
- you yourself are responsible for the perfect working order of your appliance, cf. also StudentWeb.
- keyboard stickers in the language in which the examination is conducted (such as English, German, as well as Arabic, Chinese, Russian, Japanese, etc. in language examinations) are permitted. The stickers must be identical with the original characters of the language concerned.

Any use of additional appliances that are not listed above will be strictly prohibited throughout the examination.

Any necessary actions with another software or additional appliances require the express prior approval of the persons in charge of the examination and are only permitted under supervision.

Any infringement of these rules of conduct may be sanctioned as an infringement of the rules of the University.

3. Examination sub part (3/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Written work
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Written work
Examination mode	Digital
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	Off Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	10%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
Individual Peer Feedback

Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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Content

Students must complete a midterm exam (40% of overall grade) and participate in a group presentation (50% of overall grade) during the final two days of the course (two consecutive days). They are also required to provide peer feedback on other student presentations (10% of overall grade).

For the presentation, it will be expected to use the Platform Navigator as a tool to:

- Identify and reflect on platforms in a selected industry
- Conduct a structured in-depth analysis and comparison of platform business models
- Analyse and design general and case-specific platform strategies in regard to business model, growth and KPIs

Evaluation criteria for the presentation are the following:

- Degree of innovation
- Rigor of analysis
- Potential business impact
- Presentation style

Evaluation criteria for the peer feedback are the following:

- Structure and completeness
- Specificity and evidence
- Constructiveness and actionability

Literature

- Adner, R. (2021). Winning the right game: How to disrupt, defend, and deliver in a changing world. MIT Press.
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Please note

Please note that only this fact sheet and the examination schedule published at the time of bidding are binding and takes precedence over other information, such as information on StudyNet (Canvas), on lecturers' websites and information in lectures etc.
Any references and links to third-party content within the fact sheet are only of a supplementary, informative nature and lie outside the area of responsibility of the University of St.Gallen.

Documents and materials are only relevant for central examinations if they are available by the end of the lecture period (CW21) at the latest. In the case of centrally organised mid-term examinations, the documents and materials up to CW 13 (Monday, 23rd March 2026) are relevant for testing.

Binding nature of the fact sheets:

- Course information as well as examination date (organised centrally/decentrally) and form of examination: from bidding start in CW 04 (Thursday, 22nd January 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for decentralised examinations: in CW 12 (Monday, 16 March 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised mid-term examinations: in CW 14 (Monday, 30 March 2026);
- Examination information (regulations on aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised examinations: two weeks before ending with de-registration period in CW 15 (Monday, 06 April 2026).